

2009 The IMF puts in place a 1.7 billion euro rescue package for Latvia.

2009 Government collapses as unemployment soars to 20 percent. Valdis Domrovskis of the center-right New Era party becomes prime minister.

«186–87 The Black Death
«446–47 Perestroika

Lithuania



A Baltic country at various times fought over by Russia, Germany, and Poland.

1322 Gediminas establishes the capital at Vilnius, and conquers areas of present-day Belarus. His son Algirdas expands Lithuania into present-day Ukraine.

1386 Poland and Lithuania unite; at the height of their power in the 15th century, the domains of the Jagiellonian kings stretch from the Baltic to the Black Sea.

1569 Union of Lublin binds Lithuania and Poland with a common Diet and a single capital, Warsaw.

1795 Three partitions of Poland result in Lithuania becoming Russian territory. Poles and Lithuanians join the uprisings against Russian rule in 1831 and 1863.

1915 Occupied by German troops.

1918 Independence declared.

1926 Military coup: one-party rule under Antanas Smetona.

1940 Annexed by USSR.

1941–44 Nazi occupation.

1945 Incorporated into USSR.



The last pagan

The marriage of Lithuanian Grand Prince Jagiello (above) and Queen Jadwiga of Poland in 1386 united the two countries; Jagiello, a pagan, converted to Catholicism, as did his people.

1991 Achieves full independence. Russian troops leave by 1993.

2004 Lithuania joins the EU and NATO.

2007 Lithuania's application to join the euro is turned down.

2009 Economic crisis as Lithuania's GDP declines 12.6 percent in a single year.

«186–87 The Black Death

Poland



A once-powerful Catholic nation that has been repeatedly partitioned and invaded.

966 King Mieszko, who had united three Slavonic tribes and founded the Polish Piast dynasty, becomes a Christian.

1386 Poland and Lithuania are united by the marriage of Queen Jadwiga of Poland and Grand Prince Jagiello of Lithuania. In the 15th century the Jagiellonian domains, the largest in Europe, stretch from the Baltic to the Black Sea.

1572 Sigismund August II, the last of the Jagiellonian dynasty, dies, after having concluded in 1569 the Union of Lublin, strengthening the common state of Poland and Lithuania. The two capitals of Cracow and Vilnius are replaced by a single capital city, Warsaw, in 1596.

1764 Stanislas August Poniatowski is appointed to the Polish throne through the influence of Russian Czarina Catherine II after nearly two centuries of intermittent war between Poland and its neighbors—Russia, Sweden, and the Ottoman Empire.

1772 The first partition of Poland takes place between Prussia, Austria, and Russia by the Treaty of St. Petersburg.

1791 A new liberal constitution, forced through by Stanislas, reduces the traditional powers of the nobility. The nobles call on Russia for aid.

1793 Second partition of Poland: the Treaty of Grodno divides more Polish territory between Russia and Prussia.

1795 Austria, Prussia, and Russia negotiate the third partition of Poland, and in 1797 proclaim the abolition of Poland (*Finis Poloniae*), following Stanislas August's abdication in 1795.

1807–13 Following the Treaty of Tilsit between Napoleon and Czar Alexander I, Poland is resurrected as the French vassal state of the Duchy of Warsaw.

1815 The Treaty of Vienna allocates to Russia a large portion of the Duchy.

1830–31 Insurrection in Warsaw. The Polish Diet creates a national government. Russian troops invade and take Warsaw and direct rule from Russia is imposed.

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE CREATION OF SOLIDARITY, 1980

The independent trade union Solidarity emerged out of a wave of strikes in the Gdansk shipyards in August 1980. Led by Lech Walesa, an electrician, it soon became a vehicle for Poles to demand widespread economic, social, and political changes and eventually to threaten communist rule itself.

Outlawed in 1982 after martial law was imposed, Solidarity re-emerged in the late 1980s as communism collapsed. It became a political party in 1989, electing Walesa as president of Poland in 1990. Solidarity's success sparked 1989's anti-communist revolutions throughout eastern Europe.



1846 Austria annexes Cracow, established as a republic by Treaty of Vienna.

1863 An uprising against Russian rule is suppressed with Prussian help, ending the liberal reforms of 1861–62.

1918 A Polish state is recreated out of Germany, Russia, and Austria–Hungary, after Germany's defeat in World War I.

1921 Democratic constitution.

1926–35 Pilsudski heads military coup: nine years of authoritarian rule.

1939 Germany invades and divides Poland with Russia.

1941 First Nazi concentration camps built on Polish soil.

1943 Jews in the Warsaw Ghetto rise up against German persecution.

1944 Warsaw uprising against the Germans fails as the advancing Soviet army decides not to intervene.

1945 Yalta and Potsdam conferences set present borders and determine political allegiance to USSR.

1947 Communists manipulate elections to gain power, banning opposition parties.

1970 Food price increases lead to riots in the Baltic port cities. Hundreds are killed. The government of Wladyslaw Gomulka falls.

1980 Strikes force the government to negotiate with Solidarity: Gdansk Accords grant the right to form free trade unions.

1981 General Wojciech Jaruzelski becomes prime minister.

1981–83 Martial law: Solidarity movement forced into underground

existence, and many of its leaders, including Lech Walesa, are interned. Walesa awarded Nobel Peace Prize.

1986 Amnesty for political prisoners.

1988 Renewed industrial unrest.

1989 Ruling communists hold talks with Solidarity, which is legalized again. Partially free elections are held: first post-war noncommunist government formed.

1990 Lech Walesa is elected president.

1991 Free elections lead to fragmented parliament.

1993 Elections: reformed communists head coalition. Last Russian troops leave.

1994 Launch of mass privatization.

1995 Leader of reformed communists Aleksander Kwasniewski is president.

1996 Historic Gdansk shipyard declared bankrupt and closed down.

1997 Parliament finally adopts new post-communist constitution. Legislative elections end former communist majority.

1999 Poland joins NATO.

2004 Joins the EU.

2007 The archbishop of Warsaw resigns after revelations he helped the secret police under the communist regime.

2010 National crisis after President Lech Kaczynski dies in a plane crash. His brother Jaroslaw loses presidential election to Bronislaw Komorowski of the center-right Civic Platform party.

«188–91 Medieval Europe
«306–07 The Napoleonic Wars
«448–49 Raising the Iron Curtain